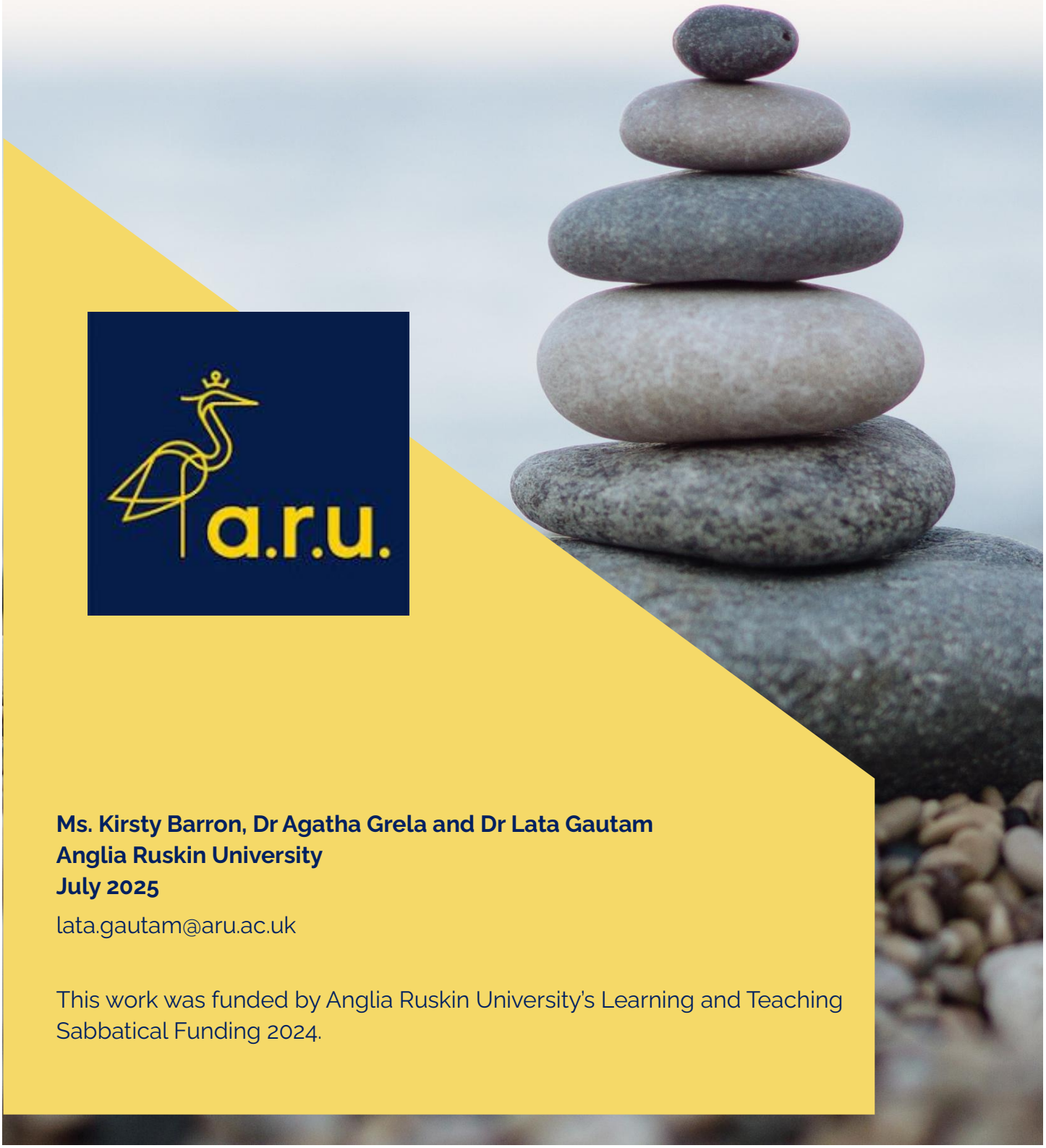
Spiking Educational Toolkit



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1. Introduction

This toolkit is designed to contain a resource about spiking for university staff and students. It explains the symptoms of spiking, where to find support services, and how to report incidents. The aim is to help everyone better understand what spiking is and to support those who may have been spiked to make informed decisions about what to do next.

Existing resources on spiking, from organisations like Spike Aware UK[1], Stamp Out Spiking[2], Life Stuff and the Talk About Trust[3], Drinkaware[4], and the Egalitarian[5] mainly focus on how to recognise the symptoms, reduce risks, stay safe, and report incidents. Our toolkit expands by incorporating guidance from Universities UK[6]. It provides more detailed information on the reporting process, what steps are involved, and the differences between anonymous and non-anonymous reporting. This information is sourced from Police UK[7,8], NHS[9,10], and the Home Office[11,12] websites.

We incorporated the feedback received to produce the final toolkit. Input was gathered from Anglia Ruskin University (ARU) students through focus groups, from staff via internal conferences, and from stakeholders through individual emails and a dedicated event hosted at ARU. This toolkit is designed primarily for use by university staff and students at ARU. However, it is adaptable for use by other universities and sectors through the customisation of institution-specific reporting and support processes.

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Spiking is a crime. You have the right not to be spiked:

- You have the right to decide what you eat and drink and what goes into your body.
- You should not have to change your behaviour to avoid being spiked.
- You should not have to avoid bars or clubs or cover your drink at all times[11].

2. What is spiking?

Spiking is when someone puts alcohol, illicit drugs or medicines into another person's drink, food or body without their consent or knowledge[7,12,13]. Drink spiking is the most common type of spiking, and the most common drug used is alcohol[2]. Other types of spiking include needling (or spiking via injection), vape/cigarette spiking and food spiking [5,7,12].

Some examples of spiking are:

- Adding an extra shot of alcohol to someone's drink
- Giving someone double shots when they asked for singles
- Adding alcohol to a non-alcoholic drink
- Adding higher strength alcohol to a lower strength drink
- Adding illicit or pharmaceutical drugs to someone's drink, food or vape/cigarette
- Injecting illicit or pharmaceutical drugs into someone else's body

3. Spiking is a crime

Spiking is a serious crime with no justification whatsoever. It instils deep fear and distress in survivors, which can lead to severe and dangerous outcomes with possible long-term health issues. Regardless of the intention, spiking is illegal and carries a sentence of up to ten years in prison[4,7,12]. If a robbery, sexual assault or other crime took place, the sentence may be even longer[7].

4. How would I know if I have been spiked?

It is not always possible to tell through smell or taste[4,14] but if you notice a change in the appearance or taste of your drink, stop drinking it. If you are in a club, bar or other venue, let a member of staff or security know as soon as you can.

There are no spiking specific symptoms. However, the following may indicate that you could have been spiked[3,4,7,13,14].

- Confusion
- Feeling very drunk after little or no alcohol
- Sudden changes in body temperature (e.g. fever or chills)
- Feeling disoriented
- Poor coordination
- Loss of balance
- Nausea (feeling sick)
- Problems with vision
- Unconsciousness

These symptoms would usually start soon after being spiked (within 15 minutes) but can vary depending on what substance was used to spike you and how your body reacts to[7]. The physical symptoms you feel can last for several hours.

Since the symptoms can vary, and they can feel like being drunk, they can be difficult to spot. If you start to feel strange, unwell or more drunk than you think you should feel, let someone know and ask for help as soon as you can.

5. How spiking can make you feel

You may also experience a range of emotions after someone spikes you, these can last longer than the physical effects but are all normal responses to a traumatic experience. You may feel angry or betrayed if someone you know spiked you. The following emotions and reactions have been reported in cases of spiking[7]:

- Shock
- Guilt
- Frustration
- Anxiety (especially around going out and socialising)
- Sadness
- Depression
- Isolation

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Everyone reacts to spiking in different ways, there is no right or wrong way to feel, and in any case, you are not to blame for being spiked. If you are struggling with any of these feelings and would like to reach out for extra support, there are some organisations and resources in the support section below (see Section 9).

6. What to do if you think you've been spiked?

If you or a friend think you've been spiked: [3-5,7,8]

- Let a member of staff or security know if you're in a venue such as a club, bar, or at a festival.
- If there is evidence like a drink or needle, keep hold of it if you can.
- Get somewhere you feel safe and stay together.
- You may want to report it to the police or seek medical attention first.
- If you need urgent medical attention, call an ambulance (999) or find your nearest urgent care service here.
- Go home with people that you trust or trusted groups or services until the effects wear off.
- Get someone you trust to stay with you until the effects of the alcohol/drugs wear off – this can take a few hours.

If you decide to report it to the police, they may collect forensic samples, e.g. urine, to test for drugs, up to 4 days after the incident. Even if you were tested in a hospital or by your GP for treatment, the police will still ask you to have a forensic test if you report within this 4-day timeframe, as this test can be used as evidence[7] in a criminal investigation.

If you think you have been spiked with a needle, you may be advised to speak to your GP or a sexual health clinic to be tested for blood borne viruses – although the risk of contracting one from a spiking incident is low[10].

7. Reporting Spiking

You can report spiking to the police or to the university (or both), and this can be done anonymously or non-anonymously. You can report an incident at any time, no matter how long ago it happened.

It is always your choice whether to report a spiking incident. Some reasons people choose to report include:

- It may help resolve your case
- It can support your emotional recovery
- It may help prevent future incidents by identifying and stopping the perpetrator

7.1. Reporting to ARU [15, 16]

If you are a student or member of staff at ARU, you can report spiking to ARU anonymously using the Report and Support Tool here[16] (from 14 July 2025).

- You can report anonymously which does not require you to identify yourself and this means that university cannot take any formal or informal action, but the information will be used to help us prevent similar incidents happening again.
- You can also report non-anonymously using Report and Support Tool. You can also reach out to the student advice centre, if you are unsure about your reporting options and want additional support.
- Spiking is a difficult issue for universities to investigate because their powers are limited and victims are encouraged to report to the police, who have the authority to review CCTV, test samples, and investigate beyond the university's context. If you are worried about seeking support because of concerns about drug use or about getting into trouble, please know that ARU is here to help. Our priority is your safety and well-being. We encourage you to reach out for support without fear of judgment or repercussions. Whatever you choose to do, ARU will be able to support staff or students affected by spiking.
- Regardless of whether you choose to report spiking or not, you can access ARU's support[17] or other support for survivors of crime, such as Victim Support[18].

7.2. Reporting to police7[,8,19]

To report spiking to the police, you can call 101 (the non-emergency line) or report a crime online[19].

- If you report spiking to the police anonymously, they may still be able to investigate but won't be able to give you updates on the investigation.
- If you report spiking non-anonymously to the police, there are a few stages of the process. You can read about the initial stages here and the investigation process here.
- Having illegal drugs in your system (unless you are driving) is not a crime. Therefore, please do not hesitate to report incidents of spiking. Even if it occurred in a private home, reporting it will not necessarily get your hosts in

trouble (unless they were responsible for the spiking). The person who spiked your drink is the one who committed the crime[7].

7.3. Your account of the incident

If you're comfortable talking about what happened, you may be asked to go over following main points:

- What happened?
- Where/ when do you think it happened?
- Do you know who might have done it?

You may have included these in your initial report, but this is a normal part of the process and doesn't mean you weren't believed the first time. It's alright if you're uncertain or don't remember exactly what happened. Drugs used for drink spiking can make you forget what happened during that time. It's like your memory of that time just disappears or can be fragmented. You will not be judged or blamed for what happened to you.

7.3.1. Collecting evidence

After reporting a spiking incident, you may be asked to provide a blood or urine sample for further investigation. You can read about forensic testing here. Currently, only the police can collect forensic evidence. In cases where spiking leads to sexual assault, Sexual Assault Referral Centres (SARCs) can also collect evidence[8].

Some drugs can leave the body within 12 hours, but others remain for longer. If you report spiking within 4 days of it happening, a police officer will visit you to provide a sterile urine collection container. They may have a doctor with them to take a blood sample. You don't have to give these samples if you don't want to.

If you report spiking more than 4 days after it happened, police will still investigate the case. In both cases, they may also visit the venue to look for other evidence including CCTV footage.

7.3.2. Police communication[7]

There will be an officer assigned to your case, who will be responsible for the investigation. They will aim to keep you updated at least every 28 days if you have provided the police with your contact details.

Investigations tend to happen over weeks and months rather than days. It can take a few weeks to get any forensic test results back and police will want to take the time to build the strongest case they can.

7.3.3. Spiking database - The Egalitarian[5]

The Egalitarian hosts a publicly viewable spiking database called Spike Report which reports how, when and where a spiking occurred as well as how the venue or emergency services

responded. You can find Spike Report here - if you choose to share information, this will be published anonymously as part of their database. Please note that this information is not used for investigative purposes.

8. Where can I find support?

Seeking support will always be a personal decision, you can access it when you are ready to. All the options below are available to you regardless of when an incident happened, and you don't have to formally report it to get support. While these resources are not specific to spiking, they can still provide valuable support.

8.1. Support at University

Your university is likely to have a counselling and wellbeing service and may have other support services for issues such as sexual violence or harassment.

You should be able to find information and links to these services on your university's website, or if you are a student, your student homepage. You can also reach out to your personal tutor or student services team for support or referral to additional services.

For ARU students[17]

You can reach out to the student services team in-person at the iCentre or online through Ask ARU. You can find out who your Personal Development Tutor (PDT) is from e:Vision, and contact them.

Counselling and Wellbeing one-to-one support is available from counsellors or mental health advisers through drop-ins either via telephone or video call. You can email wellbeing@aru.ac.uk or complete a referral form online. There are also workshops and online resources available.

Sexual Violence Support – the Sexual Violence Advocacy Service (SVA) can offer practical support and advocacy for any student who has been subjected to sexual violence, no matter when or where it happened. You can self-refer online or contact sva@aru.ac.uk to book one of the drop-in sessions.

8.2. External support – victims of any crime

Victim Support[18] –They support people affected by crime or traumatic incidents. They offer a telephone support line and live chat, as well as specific local hubs (e.g. Cambridgeshire and Essex). Additionally, they offer a range of online resources.

My Support Space[20]– A free online platform that offers a range of tools to help you cope and move forwards after any crime.

Victim Services for Cambridgeshire and Peterborough[21] – They provide emotional and practical support for victims/survivors and witnesses of crime in Cambridgeshire and Peterborough, with an online support directory, phoneline and email.

Sexual Assault Referral Centres (SARCs)[22]- If you think you were spiked and it led to you being sexually assaulted, you can also go to a SARC for specialist care, support and advice. They will also be able to conduct a forensic medical examination if you decide you want one. You can find your nearest SARC here.

8.3. Mental Health Support

Samaritans[23]– They offer a 24/7 listening service, their telephone number is 116 123 and email jo@samaritans.org. If you are struggling with your mental health and need the space to talk to someone free of judgement, when in crisis, you can contact them.

Shout[24] – A 24/7 text-based service that offers support to anyone struggling to cope (text 'shout' to 85258).

Student Minds[25] and **Student Space** offer online advice and information to help any student struggling with their mental health.

9. Myth Busting

9.1. Spiking only happens to young women.

Spiking can happen to anyone, no matter age or gender, sexuality or ethnicity. 9% of men and 13% of women responding to a 2022 survey, reported having been spiked in their lifetime. In the following year, 2.1% of men and 2.3% of women reported being spiked in the previous 12 months, almost an even split.[13]

9.2. Spiking is only done by strangers.

Spiking can be done by people we know as well as strangers. Research from 2022 found that in nearly 30% of self-reported spiking incidents, the perpetrator was someone the survivor knew[13].

9.3. Spiking only involves illegal drugs.

Many different drugs can be used in spiking, including prescription and illicit drugs as well as alcohol. A study from Students Organising for Sustainability in 2021 found that the most common substance used in spiking was alcohol[26]. This can be adding alcohol to non-alcoholic beverages and adding/ increasing strength of an already alcoholic beverage.

9.4. Spiking is only illegal if it leads to another crime.

Spiking is illegal regardless of the intent, be it to commit another crime or prank someone, including if nothing else happened after the spiking. It is a crime under multiple laws, including the Offences Against the Person Act[27], and carries a sentence of up to ten years in prison. If the spiking is followed by another crime, the sentence might be even longer[8].

9.5. I can't report spiking if I've taken other drugs willingly.

It's not a crime to have drugs in your system unless you're driving, so don't let this stop you reporting a spiking incident[7]. Police may ask you if you have taken anything, to help identify what you have taken willingly yourself and what might have been used for spiking. This is important for both investigative and intelligence purposes.

9.6. Spiking survivors have just had too much to drink.

Spiking can happen regardless of whether you've been drinking, or taking drugs, and survivors are never to blame. Although it can be hard to tell if someone has been spiked or had too much to drink (as the symptoms are very similar)[7], it's important to make sure you're safe and have medical attention if you need it.

9.7. Police and/or venue staff won't take me seriously.

Police officers are trained to understand and support victims of crime, and police work with venues to train staff to recognise and respond to spiking. A survey of 28 night-life venues in Cambridgeshire shows that 86% of them implemented initiatives related to drink spiking[13].

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